

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

2. Planning your essay

Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — <u>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</u> (2) Question — <u>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</u> (3) Call to action — <u>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</u>
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i> 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to the audience <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i> 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i>
Body paragraphs 1 & 2	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z) <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> 3. Example — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process <i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on</i>

	<i>social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i> <i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i> <i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates' holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i> Never write these (a marker spots them instantly) • invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary") • invented percentages ("87% of students") 4. Round off — echo your topic sentence <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i>
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side briefly <i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i> 2. Rebut — a concrete reason why the objection fails <i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i> 3. Round off — re-affirm your stance <i>Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i>
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a call to action.

3. Practice - Complete the following writing plan	
Question: <i>Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?</i>	
<i>Your stance: Affirmative / Negative</i>	
Title	
Introduction	
Body paragraph 1	
Body paragraph 2	
Body paragraph 3	
Conclusion	

4. Sample writing
Question: You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words) BOLD = <i>persuasive language</i> <i>Fill in each underlined blank with the linking word or signal that belongs there.</i> <u>Underlined</u> = <i>linking words and signals.</i>

Social Media: More Harm Than Good The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and _____ it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. _____, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are designed to reward comparison, _____ users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is no	Title Introduction • Hook • Stance Body 1 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Example
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longer in doubt: according to the US Surgeon General’s 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety. Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates anxiety — harm that is easy to miss _____ it feels normal. _____, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention fragmented, making deep reading almost impossible to sustain. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, _____ undermines concentration in class. Governments have reached the same conclusion: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a “digital pause”, requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, convenience is a poor defence. _____ social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. _____, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. _____, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs. Connectivity available at any hour is precisely what makes it hard to switch off, and a following built on ‘likes’ is rarely mutual support; at best, it is a short-lived substitute for friendship. _____, the convenience is real but modest, _____ the harm compounds year after year. _____, social media is not without value, _____ its effects on teenagers’ well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. Banning the technology would be counterproductive; the answer is a deliberate effort to curb the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention. (400 words)	• Round off Body 2 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Example • Round off Body 3 - Counter-argument • Concede • Rebut • Round off Conclusion • Restate stance • Summarise arguments • Final thought
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5. Language features — five reminders <i>Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. BOLD = persuasive language. Underlined = linking words.</i> Fill in each blank with the upgraded word or phrase that the poor example needs.

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary <i>no “super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”</i>	Social media <u>makes teenagers feel more worried.</u>	Social media _____ the anxiety teenagers already carry.
Passive voice ... be + past	Teenagers <u>always see</u> the perfect lives of other	Teenagers _____

participle	people on social media.	polished images of other people's lives on social media.
Persuasive language (BOLD)	Social media is <u>bad</u> for students.	Social media is _____ to teenagers' mental health. Fragmented attention makes deep reading _____ to sustain.
Linking words (<i>underlined</i>)	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate.
Avoid personal pronouns 'you'	You can see that phones are super bad for students' focus.	_____ over-reliance on smartphones _____ students' concentration.

6. Quick reference — linking words (underlined in the sample)	
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...
Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... According to + [source] + ([year]), ... Consider what happens when ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that ... However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ... On balance, ... The answer is not to ... but to ...